



Graphics Cards

The graphics segment has been quite an exciting one this year. We've had plenty of new technologies being pushed from the NVIDIA side. To start off, after an early teaser in the form of the GTX 750 and the 750 Ti, the green camp unleashed their next GPU architecture called Maxwell and the flagship cards with these GPUs provide for a median increment in performance but the wow-factor was the pricing on these cards which made them way better than all their predecessors. With Maxwell, NVIDIA seems to have finally caught up in compute power with OpenCL and OpenGL scores being in league of what AMD cards are capable of. While there are just 4 GPUs out there at the moment with the new architecture we wonder when the 960 will be launched. Going back a few generations, we've seen that the 460, 560, 660 and the 760 have all been what most gamers preferred. It has been the sweet spot and 960 is expected to be received in a similar fashion.

On AMD's side we're yet to see any new cards. Their R9 295X2 has been at the top for quite a while and a successor is soon to be launched in February next year. The R9 390X will feature the Bermuda GPU with support for HDMI 2.0 giving way for a lot higher framerates on high resolution panels. We're also hearing of rumours that the R9 390X might come with High Bandwidth Memory (HBM). AMD has been tinkering around with memory modules and even released an SSD line up this year so debuting with HBM seems to be quite plausible at the moment. A light teaser of what we can expect with the Pirate Islands GPU was seen in the R9 285 which offers much better encoding and decoding capabilities. Also, tessellation has been improved which is an avenue in which NVIDIA cards have generally been better at.

Zero1 Winner AMD R9 295X2

It was no wonder that a dual GPU graphics card was going to win the crown. So it was down to the AMD R9 295X2 and the NVIDIA TITAN Z. The R9 295X2 is a really long card and comes with an integrated liquid cooling setup. Something that the competition doesn't have and also doesn't have the



AMD R9 295X2 ▶

Price: ₹1,19,999

need to either. Cooling aside, the performance was way off the charts. Including the R9 295X2 in our usual charts will be highly unfair since all their metrics get scaled down by a ridiculous factor. So we compared it to the TITAN Z which is the only card that can even come close and it won in every benchmark except one. The surprising part is that this card is priced much lesser than the TITAN Z while being the better performer. All things considered, this card gets to win the Zero1 award in this year's round up.

Worthy Mentions

ZOTAC TITAN Z

We tested the TITAN Z first and it turned out to be thoroughly impressive. Especially since the TITAN series are more focused on compute power but NVIDIA has been marketing it as a gaming card and it does deliver on that front without any hiccups. The card has a massive amount of memory and performance wise is the second best thing to the R9 295X2. It even performs better in Bioshock Infinite but if we look at all the other games and then throw in the compute scores then the TITAN Z gets left behind. The card also commands a hefty price premium.



ZOTAC TITAN Z

Price: ₹1,39,000



NVIDIA GTX 980

Price: ₹45,999

NVIDIA GTX 980

Maxwell's flagship card stays at the top of the pyramid when you're looking at single GPU graphics cards which is why it deserves a mention here. We don't know if a 980Ti or something along the lines of two Maxwell GM204(s) in a dual chip configuration is in the works but it sure would be fun to see that. If a better value for money is what you seek then the GTX 970 is what you should go for or you can wait it out till the GTX 960 is released. 